

Word family: ****stimulate / stimulates / stimulated / stimulating / stimulation / stimulus / stimuli****

****Base word:** stimulate**

****Forms:** stimulates, stimulated, stimulating**

****Related forms:** stimulation, stimulus, stimuli**

****Part of speech:** verb (動詞) / related adjective and noun forms (相關形容詞及名詞)**

Your sentence:

> “I imagine Sapiens will be denser, sharper, and more intellectually ****stimulating****.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, ****stimulating**** means ****making the mind more active, interested, curious, or engaged****.

****繁體中文**** : ****能刺激思考的 ; 令人思想活躍、產生興趣或深入思考的****

****中文翻譯**** :

> “...more intellectually ****stimulating****.”

「.....在思想上更****具啟發性 / 更能刺激思考****。」

Here:

****intellectually stimulating = 能令大腦更活躍、引發思考和好奇心的****

1. ****stimulate = make someone think or feel more mentally active (思考) — 刺激 ; 啟發****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

****Meaning:**** To make the mind more active, interested, curious, or engaged.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The book seems intellectually ****stimulating****.”

「這本書似乎很****能刺激思考 / 富有啟發性****。」

Practice 2

> “Good questions ****stimulate**** discussion.”

「好的問題能****激發****討論。」

Practice 3

> “The lecture **stimulated** my interest in history.”

「這場講座**激發了**我對歷史的興趣。」

stimulate = 令人的思想、興趣、好奇心或討論變得更活躍

Common:

- * stimulate thinking
- * stimulate interest
- * stimulate discussion
- * intellectually stimulating

2. **stimulate** = cause activity or growth (活動 / 發展) — 促進 ; 刺激

Stimulate can mean to cause a process, system, industry, economy, organ, etc. to become more active.

Practice 4

> “The policy was designed to **stimulate** economic growth.”

「這項政策旨在**刺激 / 促進**經濟增長。」

Practice 5

> “Exercise can **stimulate** blood circulation.”

「運動可以**促進**血液循環。」

stimulate = 令某個過程、活動或系統增加運作、增長或反應

Common:

- * stimulate growth
- * stimulate demand
- * stimulate the economy
- * stimulate circulation

This is a major broad sense.

3. **stimulate = cause a physical or biological response (生理) — 刺激 ; 使產生反應**

In medicine, biology, and physiology, **stimulate** means to trigger activity or a response in a nerve, muscle, organ, cell, etc.

Practice 6

> “The drug **stimulates** the nervous system.”

「這種藥物會**刺激**神經系統。」

Practice 7

> “Light **stimulates** certain cells in the eye.”

「光線會**刺激**眼睛中的某些細胞。」

stimulate = 對身體、神經、器官或細胞施加刺激，使其產生生理反應

This is a distinct biological/medical sense.

4. **stimulate = encourage demand, interest, or activity (市場 / 行為) — 刺激 ; 帶動**

Stimulate can describe encouraging people to buy, act, participate, or respond.

Practice 8

> “Lower prices may **stimulate** demand.”

「較低價格可能會**刺激需求**。」

Practice 9

> “The campaign helped **stimulate** public interest.”

「這場活動有助**提升 / 激發**公眾興趣。」

stimulate = 透過某種因素使需求、興趣、活動量或參與程度增加

For strict counting, this belongs under Meaning 2.

5. **stimulating = exciting or energizing (令人振奮 / 活躍) — 刺激的 ; 令人精神振奮的**

Stimulating can describe experiences, conversations, environments, or activities that make someone feel mentally or emotionally energized.

Practice 10

> “We had a very **stimulating** conversation.”

「我們進行了一場非常**有啟發性 / 令人投入的**對話。」

Practice 11

> “She enjoys working in a **stimulating** environment.”

「她喜歡在一個**富有刺激性、能激發思考的**環境中工作。」

stimulating = 能令思想、情緒或精神狀態變得更活躍的

This belongs to Meaning 1.

Related form: **stimulation**

Stimulation means the act or process of stimulating.

mental stimulation — 思想刺激

Practice 12

> “Children need plenty of mental **stimulation**.”

「兒童需要足夠的**腦力刺激 / 思想刺激**。」

physical/biological stimulation — 生理刺激

Practice 13

> “The treatment involves electrical **stimulation** of the muscle.”

「這項治療涉及對肌肉進行電力**刺激**。」

stimulation = 令某個心理、生理或系統過程變得更活躍的刺激作用

Related form: **stimulus**

A **stimulus** is something that causes a response, reaction, or increase in activity.

Practice 14

> “Light is a visual **stimulus**.”

「光是一種視覺**刺激**。」

Practice 15

> “The tax cut provided a **stimulus** to the economy.”

「減稅為經濟提供了**刺激作用**。」

stimulus = 引發反應、活動或增長的刺激因素

Plural:

> **stimuli**

Important distinction: **stimulate** vs **inspire**

stimulate

means make thinking, activity, interest, or response more active.

inspire

usually means give someone motivation, ideas, or emotional encouragement.

> stimulate discussion

> inspire someone to write

They overlap, but **inspire** is usually more motivational or creative.

Important distinction: **stimulate** vs **encourage**

encourage

means give support or increase the likelihood of something happening.

stimulate

suggests actively triggering or increasing activity.

> encourage reading

> stimulate interest in reading

****Stimulate**** is often stronger and more process-focused.

Important distinction: ****stimulate vs provoke****

****provoke****

means cause a reaction, often strong or negative.

****stimulate****

usually sounds more neutral or positive.

> provoke anger

> stimulate thought

A question can both provoke thought and stimulate thought, but ****provoke**** often sounds sharper.

Important distinction: ****stimulating vs interesting****

****interesting****

means holding your attention.

****stimulating****

goes further: it actively makes you think, respond, or become mentally energized.

A book can be interesting without being deeply stimulating.

Important distinction: ****stimulating vs thought-provoking****

thought-provoking

specifically means making you think deeply about an issue.

stimulating

is broader and can refer to:

- * intellectual activity
- * discussion
- * interest
- * physical activity
- * biological response

So in your passage:

> **intellectually stimulating**

is very close to:

> **thought-provoking**

but not identical.

Grammar note

Stimulate is usually transitive:

> stimulate **something/someone**

Examples:

- * stimulate the economy
- * stimulate interest
- * stimulate the brain
- * stimulate discussion

Not normally:

> "The economy stimulated." ❌

Instead:

- > “The economy was stimulated.”
- > “The economy grew.”

Countability note

****Stimulation**** is usually uncountable:

- > mental stimulation
- > electrical stimulation

****Stimulus**** is countable:

- > a stimulus
- > several stimuli

This distinction is useful.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

- * ****stimulate****
- * ****stimulates****
- * ****stimulated****
- * ****stimulating****
- * ****stimulation****
- * ****stimulus****
- * ****stimuli****

The main semantic branches are mental activation, broader activation/growth, and biological/physical response. Different objects such as ****economy, interest, discussion, circulation**** should not automatically become separate meanings if the underlying concept remains “cause greater activity.”

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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stimulate — mental	令思想、興趣、好奇心或討論變得更活躍；激發、啟發
stimulate — activity/growth	令某個過程、系統、需求或活動增加運作或增長
stimulate — biological	刺激神經、肌肉、器官或細胞，使其產生生理反應
stimulating	能令思想、精神或活動變得更活躍；富啟發性

stimulation	刺激作用；使心理、生理或系統變得活躍的過程	
stimulus	引發反應、活動或增長的刺激因素	

For your original sentence

> “I imagine Sapiens will be denser, sharper, and more intellectually **stimulating**.”

The exact meaning is:

****stimulating = 這本書會令讀者的思想更活躍，引發更多分析、好奇和深入思考****

So:

> ****intellectually stimulating****

= ****在思想上很有刺激性 / 很能啟發思考****

For your database, I would count ****3 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****stimulate****:

1. ****activate thinking, interest, curiosity, or discussion****
2. ****increase activity, growth, demand, or functioning in a system/process****
3. ****trigger a physical or biological response****

I would merge economic, commercial, and general activity examples into #2, and keep ****stimulating / stimulation / stimulus**** as family extensions rather than inflate the verb count.